WORLD INDICATORS · 217 COUNTRIES

World indicators tell one connected story

Income shapes health and digital access, while the pandemic and data gaps complicate the picture.



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THE CENTRAL RELATIONSHIP

Income is the master variable

Log GDP per capita correlations

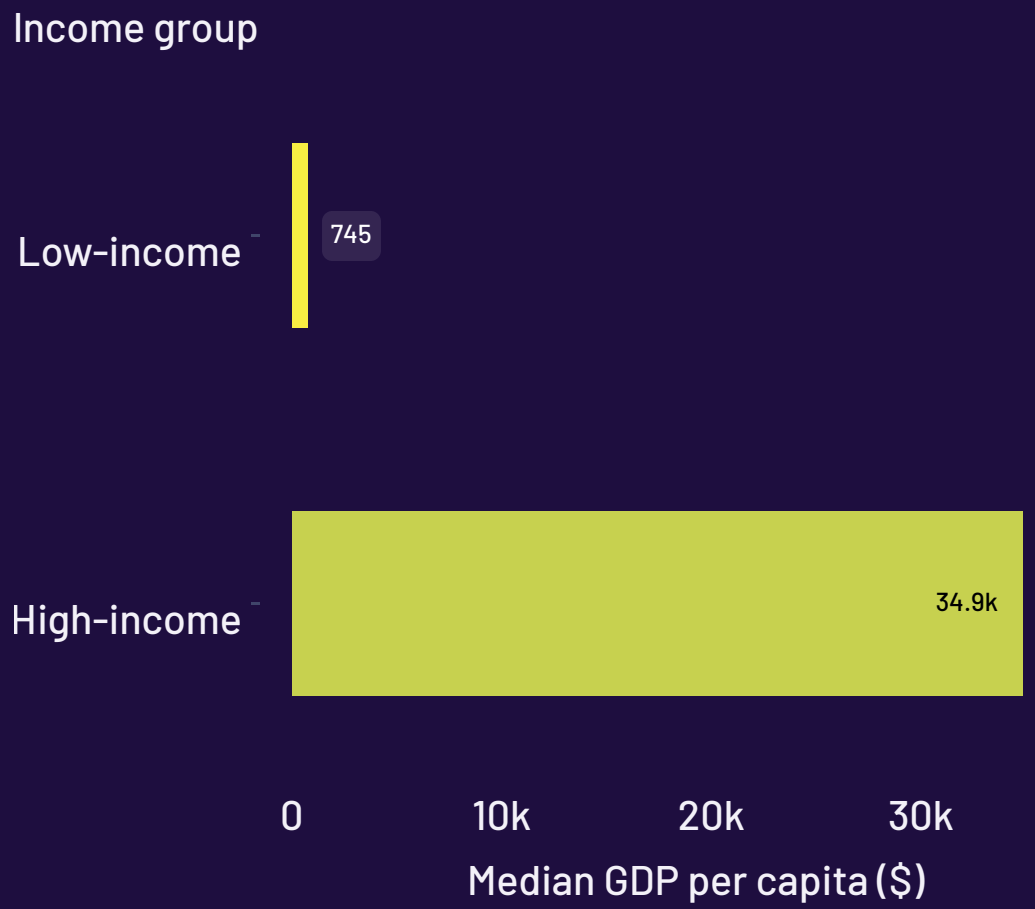
Across 217 countries

0.87

Correlation with life expectancy

0.88

Correlation with internet use



In 2022, median GDP per capita ranged from $745 to $34,861. Life expectancy spans 63.6 to 81.2 years across the same groups.

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A TEST OF THE STORY

Health spending alone does not close the gap

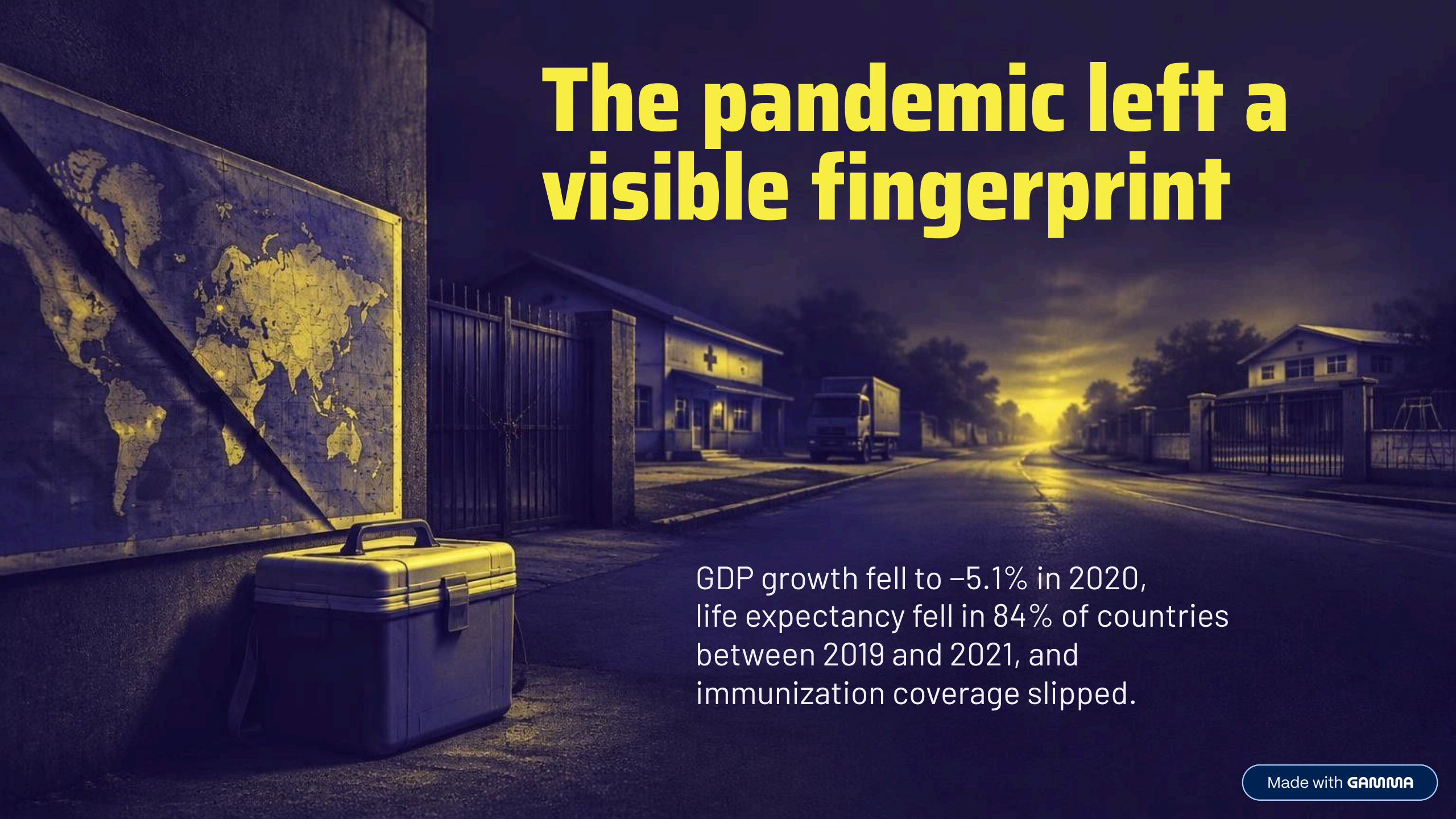
Model signal	Correlation	Read
Health expenditure → life expectancy	0.24	Weak relationship
Log GDP per capita → life expectancy	0.84	Much stronger
Income + health spending, 2021	$R^2 = 0.70$	Still incomplete

> Per-capita spending, not share of GDP, is the more useful next test.

Relationships are correlations. Many indicators are modeled estimates.

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The pandemic left a visible fingerprint



GDP growth fell to –5.1% in 2020, life expectancy fell in 84% of countries between 2019 and 2021, and immunization coverage slipped.

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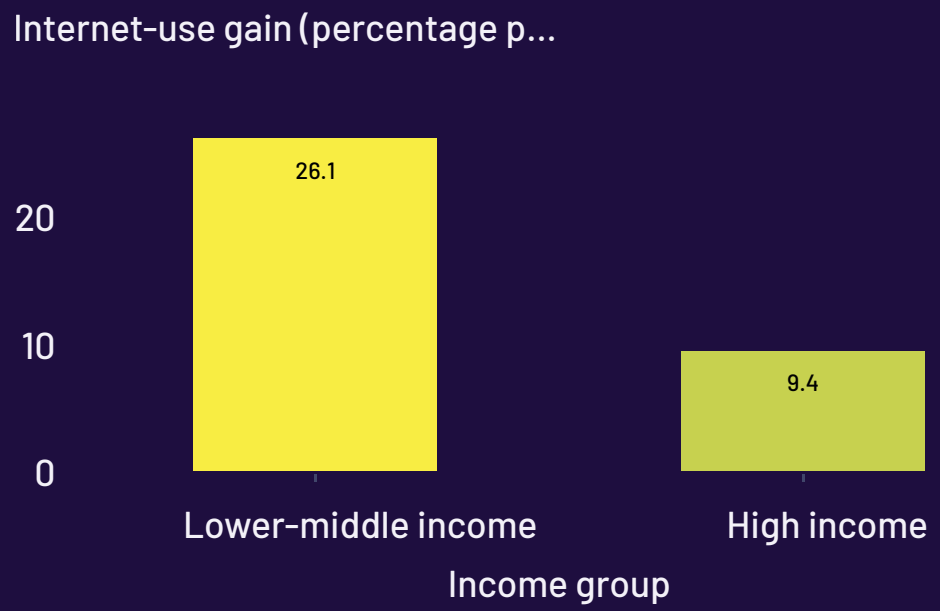
THE CATCH-UP PATTERN

Digital access is catching up fastest in the middle

54% → 81%

Median internet use, 2016 to 2023

26.1 points gained by lower-middle-income countries, 2016–2022; **9.4 points** gained by high-income countries.



Starting level and gain are negatively related, a clear catch-up pattern.

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THE LIMIT OF CONNECTIVITY

Connectivity is not a shortcut to jobs

0.88

Internet use correlates with GDP per capita

−0.83

Internet use correlates with infant mortality

0.03

Spearman relationship with unemployment: essentially zero

22.5%

Youth unemployment is a regional story in the Middle East and North Africa in 2023.

Connectivity aligns with development, but unemployment remains a regional story.

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CONCENTRATION AND COVERAGE

Trade is concentrated, while poverty evidence is thin

Trade concentration

34.9%

Top 5 exporters' share of exports, 2022

49.3%

Top 10 exporters' share of exports, 2022

Poverty evidence

71

Countries report at least two poverty observations.

Regional comparisons are unreliable. Largest reported poverty declines include Viet Nam, Uzbekistan and Georgia.

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Data quality changes the answer

2016–2023

Effective analytical window; 2024 is nearly empty.

20%

Country-years with poverty data

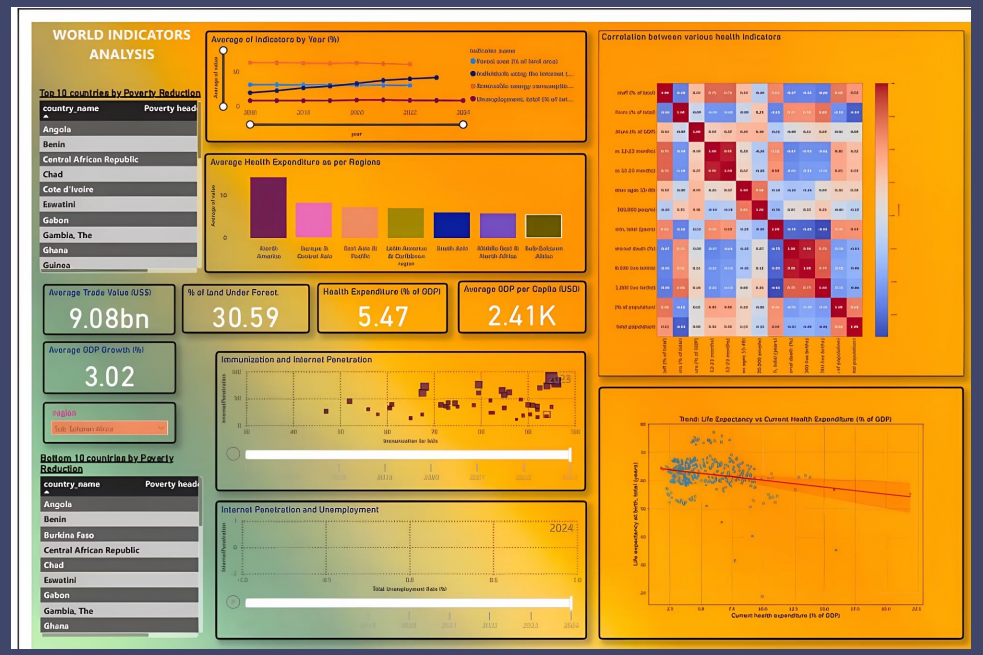
9%

Country-years with cause-of-death data

6.7×

Including aggregates inflated average trade value until the dashboard was corrected.

Missing data is heavy for poverty, Gini and cause of death. Averages are unweighted by population.



Dashboard reference

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DEFAULTS FOR RESPONSIBLE USE

Use the dashboard with disciplined defaults

1 **Exclude aggregates**

Exclude regional and income aggregates from country averages.

2 **Choose robust summaries**

Use medians for skewed indicators and state the country count behind every average.

3 **Refresh and test**

Refresh the source, add per-capita health spending and test population-weighted, fixed-effects models.

Relationships are correlations. Treat the dashboard as a disciplined starting point, not a final answer.

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